



HSBA

Rules and Guidelines for Written Assignments and Theses

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Applicable to all scientific documents written at HSBA are Sections 6 (Referencing), 7 (Artificial Intelligence), 8 (Declaration of Honor), and 9 (Submission) as well as Annex 1 to this document. All other contents only pertain to Bachelor's and Master's Theses.

1. Introduction

Your Bachelor or Master thesis will aim at closing a research gap by answering an immediate and compelling question in a scientific manner. This question might emanate either from within your company or via your own academic interest. It ties together a variety of skills acquired throughout your study program and rounds off your respective academic training. Writing your thesis gives you the chance to:

- Demonstrate your proficiency in the scientific method
- Become an expert in a field of your interest
- Sharpen your academic and professional profile
- Train your skills of reasoned argument

To contribute to the scientific discourse in your subject area, you will:

- Problematize why your topic of choice is both of immediate interest and relevance to your target audience
- Lay out and critically scrutinize the literature on the topic
- Choose or develop the appropriate qualitative or quantitative method to tackle your research question

- Derive conclusions and discuss possible generalizations as well as limitations of your research.

The details of the research process together with the most important practical aspects are laid out for your reference below. The following sections also detail rules and guidelines on format and presentation, different types of theses, scientific referencing, and finally, the supervisor's role.

2. The Process

- a) **Proposal Drafting:** To attain the consent of a supervisor to supervise your thesis, you draft a Research Proposal containing an exposition of essential background literature, research aims, methodology and potential implications of your thesis. The specifics of this document will be covered in section 12 of these Guidelines.
- b) **Registration:** After having attained consent of supervision, you will register your thesis topic by handing in the application form provided on Microsoft Teams. After positive internal review you will receive approval of your topic together with the deadline for submission. From this moment forward you may not change your thesis topic. Registration typically occurs toward the end of your studies, earliest for Bachelor students after completing 100 out of 180 ECTS and all exams from the first study year, for Master students after completing 50% of their respective ECTS.
- c) **Completion Period:** Bachelors' theses will have to be completed within 9 weeks, respectively in the Bachelor part-time program within 12 weeks. For Master's theses please refer to the time periods specified in the respective programs. All time periods apply from the date of approval of the proposed topic.
- d) **Results Notification:** Students will receive note of their marks as well as copies of the assessment reports via e-mail.
- e) **Colloquium:** The colloquium is a forum for students to expose, contextualize and defend the insights generated through their theses. Typically, the duration falls within 30 to 45 minutes. Students will learn about their mark at the end of their colloquium.

3. The Structure of Your Thesis

Theses vary in structure and there is no one-size-fits-all blanket rule that will work for everyone. However, scientific pieces often follow a certain chain of reasoning which is illustrated by the following typical components. In general, it is important to allow for reproducibility - that is, an interested third party should be able to retrace your arguments and research steps and replicate (as closely as possible) your findings:

Introduction

The Introduction as a figurehead of a scientific work will outline the general topic covered, why it is of interest, what its relevance is and to whom. Consideration will be given as to how the topic chosen emanates from a practical problem from within the business context. Both the research gap as well as the research question will clearly be outlined. Key findings and their implications will be summarized. Finally, the structure for the remainder of the study can be briefly summarized. However, please note that this overview should extend well beyond a general list of section headlines and should provide true added value.

Conceptual Foundations

Conceptual Foundations contain a summary of literature in a concise fashion regarding cutting edge findings of other researchers on the topic. This serves the purpose to situate your own contribution within the discourse in literature and to emphasize the need for further study. Thereby, unanswered questions should be highlighted, and attention drawn once more to the specific research gap you aim to close. Thereby, the value of your thesis' contribution to the body of literature is underlined.

Correspondingly, it is outlined how research questions emanating from the literature translate into a conceptual framework aimed at formulating, justifying, and testing specific propositions and hypotheses. The research methods employed (quantitative, qualitative or both) will be explained and their selection justified.

Application, Scientific Analysis & Discussion

Insofar as the research methodology previously developed rests on the use of data and models (theoretical or empirical), such will find application here. The data collection process will be described and qualified. The nature of samples and/ or cases selected will be discussed. Checks for plausibility & robustness to assess model validity will be conducted. Results gathered will scientifically be analyzed.

The Discussion will thereafter lay out key findings of your thesis and critically examine them in the light of previous considerations. Vital to this section is:

- a) To reflect upon your results against hypotheses and propositions formulated as well as extant literature presented in the Literature Review.
- b) To interpret the results gathered to derive the specific meaning of your findings.

Conclusion

Within the Conclusion the key findings are summarized in a concise fashion and their significance and implications highlighted – for academia and practice. A critical examination of possible limitations to the research, future avenues of inquiries as well as an outlook round off the thesis.

4. Types of Theses

While theses written at HSBA will often be built around empirical work based on data of various kinds (either primary or secondary), it is also possible to write a purely literature-based thesis.

However, this is a particularly challenging task. Literature-based theses will have to go well beyond summarizing or restating existing literature in a descriptive manner and provide a critical analysis, framework or adjudication that adds in a considerable fashion to the discourse around a specific stream of thought.

While this endeavor is indeed possible, please be advised to consider the implications carefully and to thoroughly discuss them with your supervisor prior to settling on a course of action.

5. Format of the Thesis

There are multiple elements that need to be included in the order as presented below:

- A Cover Page with the following pieces of information:
 - The Title and Subtitle of the Thesis
 - Type of document (i.e. Bachelor's Thesis or Master's Thesis)
 - The student's full name and date of birth
 - The student's matriculation number
 - Supervisor's name
 - Word count
 - Name of the study program and academic institution
 - Academic year and date of submission
 - If desired, name of cooperating business
 - HSBA Logo (available from Microsoft Teams)
- Restriction Notice (if desired or required)
- A full Table of Contents with page number references
- Lists of Tables, Figures and Abbreviations (if such are employed within the document)
- Acknowledgements (if any)
- Abstract with a maximum of 300 words
- Main body (Sections) of the thesis
- A full Reference List / Bibliography (depending on the chosen citation format)
- A full list of prompts submitted to AI tools
- Appendices (if any)
- Supplemental material needs to be added in a zip-file
- Declaration of Honor (see below)

The different elements outlined above must adhere to the following guidelines in respect of format:

Length and presentation

The thesis must be submitted as Word document (not applicable if you submit it in LaTeX) **and** pdf-document and **must not exceed:**

- For Bachelor's and MBA's Theses: 12,000 words (this includes references (regardless of the referencing style; see "6. Referencing"), tables and footnotes but excludes the title page, abstract, contents pages etc., illustrations, reference list and appendices). As a yardstick for your own work, please refer to published journal articles which will give you a general impression regarding format and presentation.
- For Master of Science Theses: 18,000 words (this includes references (regardless of the referencing style; see "6. Referencing"), tables and footnotes but excludes the title page, abstract, contents pages etc., illustrations, reference list and appendices).

Spacing

Either one and a half or double spacing are recommended to be used in the typescript (please discuss this with your supervisor), except for quotations or footnotes where single spacing should be used. Quotations must be indented.

Pagination and Labeling

All Sections must be clearly identified and labeled and all Sub-Sections within them properly numbered (e.g. 1.1, 1.2 etc.). The Acknowledgements, Abstract, Lists of Tables/ Figures/ Abbreviations, Contents page(s) must be numbered using continuous Roman numerals. All following pages must be sequentially numbered with Arabic numerals starting from the beginning of Section 1 (Introduction).

Footnotes

Footnotes must be clearly numbered. They should appear at the bottom of the respective pages where references to the issue are raised. It is recommended, however, that footnotes be *avoided* as much as possible, except for citation purposes, if the Notes and Bibliography format of referencing is chosen (see Chapter 6 below).

Formulas

When using formulas and mathematical symbols, it is important to ensure professional typesetting. In Word you should use the equation editor while in LaTeX you would use the math mode. Short formulas like $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$ can be specified in the running text. More complex or particularly important formulas can appear in a separate line. As shown in the example of formula (1), a number can be given in brackets next to the formula in the right margin for easier referencing:

$$\bar{X} = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n X_i \quad (1)$$

6. Referencing: The Chicago Style of Documentation

Please note that it is *Plagiarism* to take verbatim quotes from literature without giving due reference to the source(s) and/ or using quote marks. Any discovery of Plagiarism is liable to severe penalties in accordance with HSBA Regulations.

The basis for citation rules in theses at HSBA is the Chicago Manual of Style (www.chicagomanualofstyle.org). For any questions regarding citation practice, please refer to the well documented information presented in the book or the corresponding online resources. The manual suggests two options for referencing sources in scientific work: The *Notes and Bibliography* as well as *Author Date* styles.

We strongly recommend the Author- Date format for its prevalence in the sciences of business and economics. Whichever style ultimately finds application, it is important to be consistent in your citation style throughout your thesis. For your reference, examples of proper citation will be given in Annex 1 to this document.

To save a considerable amount of work and time, you use citation managers/ software. Among the different packages available we recommend Mendeley, which is also covered in the various lectures at HSBA on academic writing. Further options include Microsoft's built-in citation manager, Citavi, Endnote or JabRef, which we recommend if you choose to work with LaTeX.

Author-Date References

Within the Author-Date system of citation, sources are marked in the text of the body by stating the author's last name, the year of publication and, in general, the page number of relevant content in parentheses (for the handling of page number referencing, please see paragraph "Source Handling" below). All cited sources are summarized with the full source information in a reference list at the end of the thesis.

In-text examples

A sample is understood as a sub section of the entirety of possible observations, called population (Kmenta 2000, 3).

A sample is understood as a sub section of the entirety of possible observations, called population (Kmenta 2000, 3; Müller 2020, 8).

Kmenta (2000, 3) defines a sample as a sub section of the entirety of possible observations, called population.

Kmenta (2000, 3) and Müller (2020, 8) define a sample as a sub section of the entirety of possible observations, called population.

Corresponding references section example

Kmenta, Jan. 2000. *Elements of Econometrics*. Ann Arbor: The University of Michigan Press.

Notes and Bibliography

If you expressly wish to deviate from the HSBA recommendation and use the Notes and Bibliography style instead, please confer with your supervisor before doing so to clarify questions of appropriateness and consent. As the name implies, this citation style employs a combination of footnotes and bibliography. Citations are marked in the body of the text with continuous superscript numbers after relevant passages in conjunction with the source cited in the footnotes as well as in the bibliography. Further details are given in the paragraph "Source Handling".

In-text example

In statistical inference, a sample is understood as a sub section of the entirety of possible observations, called population¹.

Corresponding bibliography example

Kmenta, Jan. *Elements of Econometrics*. Ann Arbor: The University of Michigan Press, 2000.

Source Handling

Please note that only cited sources are to be included in the References or Bibliography sections. Page numbers have to be specified regardless of the source type.

Supplementary Guideline: Expert Interview Documentation

Regarding the documentation of expert interviews, the following recommendations apply:

- a) If reasonable in the light of quantity and length of expert interviews conducted, it is recommended to transcribe the conversation(s) in full and include transcripts in the appendix of the thesis.
- b) If due to the length and/ or quantity of interviews conducted transcription cannot reasonably be expected, all interviews are recommended to be submitted as audio files and referenced within the thesis with file location on the storage medium, file name and time stamp (hour:minute:second).

Whether interviews conducted fall into either of the two categories a) or b) outlined above is to be discussed with the responsible supervisor.

¹ Kmenta, *Elements of Econometrics*, 3-4.

7. Artificial Intelligence (AI)

Information created by AI tools is not scientific sources and can therefore not be used as evidence for statements. Citable sources are characterized by the fact that

1. they were published in a (preferably permanent) medium and can therefore be traced and checked,
2. they were produced by authors who take responsibility for the correctness with their name and
3. in the case of scientific publications, they have undergone a quality-assuring peer review process.

None of this is currently the case with AI-generated information.

Moreover, texts created by AI tools currently do not have the depth needed for scientific work. The texts produced by chatbots are linguistically sound, but, in terms of content, often remain superficial, vague and may even turn out to be false on closer inspection (even "references" given in these texts can turn out to be false upon verification).

Consequently, it is not correct to use information provided by AI tools unreflectively as a component for one's own argumentation. It is therefore necessary to critically evaluate and independently verify the accuracy and validity of information generated by AI tools (cf. *declaration of honor*).

Especially when citing sources, you **must** have actually read them and prove this by precisely stating the source and page number. Please also bear in mind: You will often only notice the above-mentioned erroneous information if you have already dealt with the subject matter and acquired knowledge **in the respective field**.

In case you choose to use AI tools for the generation of information for your scientific document, you have to

- mark the use of information generated by AI tools at the corresponding locations in the document (analogously to citations from the literature);
- provide a list with all the queries and prompts submitted to AI tools used for the generation of information integrated in the document. This list must appear after the list of references and contains for each entry the name of the AI tool, the prompt, and the date.

Note: The above rules do not apply to AI tools that only translate or proofread texts.

8. Declaration of Honor

Note: It is a serious offence and grave malpractice to plagiarize another person's work, to include contents deliberately created by other persons for one's own work without clearly stating this, or to, in any other way, make use of intellectual material not devised by oneself without giving due reference. Violations can lead to the disqualification of offenders. It is hereby irrelevant whether plagiarism has occurred with deliberate intent or through negligence.

Every thesis (or assignment/project report/term paper/practical report/essay, presentation) will include a declaration of honor, assuring that the document is fully compliant with the rules and regulations of orderly scientific practice. The required text (in English or German language) is the following:

Declaration:

I hereby declare that I

- 1. wrote this bachelor's thesis/master's thesis (or assignment/project report/term paper/practical report/essay/presentation), for which the following declarations also apply) without the assistance of others;*
- 2. have critically evaluated and independently verified the accuracy and validity of information generated by AI tools, ensuring a comprehensive review of all references and outputs provided by these tools before integrating them into my academic work;*
- 3. have provided a list with all the queries and prompts submitted to AI tools used for the generation of information integrated in this thesis;*
- 4. have marked direct quotes used from the literature and the use of ideas of other authors as well as information generated by AI tools at the corresponding locations in the thesis;*
- 5. have not presented this thesis for any other exam.*

I acknowledge that a false declaration will have legal consequences.

(Place, date)

(Signature)

I accept that HSBA may check the originality of my work using a range of manual and computer-based techniques, including transferring and storing my submission in a database for the purpose of data-matching to help detect plagiarism.

(Place, date)

(Signature)

Erklärung:

Ich erkläre hiermit, dass ich

- 1. diese Bachelor-/Masterarbeit (oder Hausarbeit/Projektbericht/Seminararbeit/Praxisbericht/Essay/ Präsentation), für die auch die folgenden Erklärungen gelten, ohne fremde Hilfe verfasst habe;*
- 2. die Richtigkeit und Gültigkeit der von KI-Tools generierten Informationen kritisch bewertet und unabhängig überprüft habe, wobei ich alle Referenzen und Ergebnisse dieser Tools einer gründlichen Prüfung unterzogen habe, bevor ich sie in meine akademische Arbeit integriert habe;*
- 3. eine Liste mit allen Abfragen und Aufforderungen an die KI-Tools für die Generierung von Informationen, die in dieser Arbeit integriert wurden, vorgelegt habe;*
- 4. direkte Zitate aus der Literatur und die Verwendung der Ideen anderer Autoren sowie von KI-Tools generierte Informationen an den entsprechenden Stellen in der Arbeit gekennzeichnet habe;*
- 5. diese Arbeit nicht für eine andere Prüfung vorgelegt habe.*

Ich nehme zur Kenntnis, dass eine falsche Erklärung rechtliche Konsequenzen nach sich zieht.

(Ort, Datum)

(Unterschrift)

Ich erkläre mich damit einverstanden, dass die HSBA die Originalität meiner Arbeit mit Hilfe verschiedener manueller und computergestützter Verfahren überprüft, einschließlich der Übertragung und Speicherung meiner Arbeit in einer Datenbank zum Zwecke des Datenabgleichs, um Plagiate zu erkennen.

(Ort, Datum)

(Unterschrift)

9. Submission

The thesis (or assignment/project report/term paper/practical report/essay/presentation) has to be uploaded as a pdf document in due time to WISEflow. The original Word document (not applicable if you use LaTeX) and further additional material (compressed in a zip file) have to be uploaded as appendix material. Submission can only be assumed to have occurred once the receipt of the thesis has been recorded.

Any thesis not submitted by the deadline is graded as a fail.

Please note that petitions for extensions of the deadline must be lodged with the examination management.

10. Assessment Criteria

There is a broad range of assessment criteria applicable to the multitude of theses written in the scientific arena. Among these, a handful of common elements persist:

- What is the level of difficulty and aspiration, respectively.
- Has an interesting, relevant and current topic been discovered and translated into a clear-cut research question?
- Does the thesis succeed in contributing to the discourse within the field?
- Has salient literature been identified, synthesized and critically examined and contrasted?
- Have scientific theories, models and/or methods been considered?
- Was the student able to choose and reflect upon the proper methods of data collection and research?
- Did the student display the ability to contextualize his results and discuss findings critically to derive robust practical implications?
- Does the document show a clear structure, is well formatted, free from grammatical and spelling errors and supported by an appropriate writing style?
- **Has the research question been answered successfully?**

11. The Role of Supervisors

The supervisor's role can best be described as that of a mentor. In order to receive useful guidance in the process of completing your thesis, please make sure to pick a supervisor specializing in your field of interest and get in touch as early as you can. The individual involvement of supervisors in the respective thesis projects varies greatly. However, commonly supervisors will provide guidance to students regarding their general thrust of argument as well as the structure of their document. Counsel will typically be provided regarding appropriate literature as well as concerning methodological questions arising in connection with empirical work.

Please note that although supervisors are expected to comment on the work as it develops, at no stage should they be expected to read a full draft.

For any questions regarding HSBA regulations (e.g. regarding deadlines, formalities etc.), please refer to the currently valid study and examination regulations (ASPO) and the Examination management.

12. Research Proposal

The Research Proposal is - due to its conduciveness – a first cornerstone to a well prepared, structured and successful thesis. It helps you to reflect upon your research idea, extant literature, data acquisition, methodology as well as the relevance of your topic and its possible implications. Therefore, possible obstacles and weaknesses are discovered early on in the process, giving you the opportunity to adjust your scope and/ or methodology.

Prior to composing your Research Proposal make sure to engage in a first discussion with your supervisor to clarify the general feasibility of your thesis project.

Proposals for Master's Theses

Besides a suitable title your Research Proposal should include the following sections typically encountered in scientific documents, with indicative word count per section:

- | | |
|---|--------------------------------|
| a) Introduction | (100 words) |
| b) Background literature | (300 words) |
| c) Research aims | (100 words) |
| d) Methodology Incl. data, collection, analysis | (500 words) |
| e) Potential implications of research | (100 words) |
| f) References | (excluded from the word count) |

Proposals for Bachelor's Theses

In preparation for Bachelor's theses we recommend a simplified form of the Research Proposal comprising brief elaborations on your research question, key literature and appropriate methodology. Nevertheless, ambitious Bachelor's students are invited to follow the long form as given above for Master's theses.

In the process of writing your Research Proposal, the following questions might be helpful as guidelines:

- **What is my specific research aim?**
 - Have I specified a concise research question?
 - Can I break the research question down into specific issues and am I capable of methodologically tackling these?
- **Why is my research significant?**
 - What is cutting-edge knowledge on the subject?
 - What new insights will I generate?
 - What are the possible implications for academia?
 - What are the possible implications for business and policy?
- **How is my research methodology suitable to answer my research question?**
 - What data are adequate and necessary?
 - How can I collect the data?
 - What are obstacles and how can I gain access to the data?
 - Which method of analysis (qualitative or quantitative) should I employ?
 - Am I able to complete my research project within the time limit?

13. Sources

These academic rules and guidelines aim at providing a synthesis of frameworks tailored to the specific requirements of HSBA. The following two sources have received preeminent attention:

University of Chicago Press Staff, Multiple, ed. 2017. *Chicago Manual of Style*. 17th ed.

Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

University of London - King's College London Staff, Multiple. 2012. "Introduction to MSc Dissertations." London.

***To all students, immersing themselves in their scientific work, the best of fortune,
persistence, and success.***

Annex 1: Chicago Manual of Style Referencing

The Chicago Manual of Style suggests the following formats for various source types within the two styles *Author-Date* as well as *Notes & Bibliography*. Please note that sources from the legal context are referenced solely via the *Notes & Bibliography* styles and are thus omitted from *Author-Date* referencing.

a) ***Author-Date References (recommended)***

In-text citations follow the usual format (Author Year, Page Number) thus examples given are limited to the *References* section.

1. **Book**

Grazer, Brian, and Charles Fishman. 2015. *A Curious Mind: The Secret to a Bigger Life*. New York: Simon & Schuster.

2. **Chapter of Edited Book**

Thoreau, Henry David. 2016. "Walking." In *The Making of the American Essay*, edited by John D'Agata, 167–95. Minneapolis: Graywolf Press.

3. **E-Book with available link (without link, see 1.)**

Kurland, Philip B., and Ralph Lerner, eds. 1987. *The Founders' Constitution*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press. <http://press-pubs.uchicago.edu/founders/>.

4. **Journal Article**

LaSalle, Peter. 2017. "Conundrum: A Story about Reading." *New England Review* 38 (1): 95–109.

5. **Newspaper Report/ Magazine Article/ Blog Article**

Manjoo, Farhad. 2017. "Snap Makes a Bet on the Cultural Supremacy of the Camera." *New York Times*, March 8, 2017. <https://www.nytimes.com/2017/03/08/technology/snap-makes-a-bet-on-the-cultural-supremacy-of-the-camera.html>.

6. **Interview**

Stamper, Kory. 2017. "From 'F-Bomb' to 'Photobomb,' How the Dictionary Keeps Up with English." Interview by Terry Gross. *Fresh Air*, NPR, April 19, 2017. Audio, 35:25. <http://www.npr.org/2017/04/19/524618639/from-f-bomb-to-photobomb-how-the-dictionary-keeps-up-with-english>.

7. **Website**

Google. 2017. "Privacy Policy." Privacy & Terms. Last modified April 17, 2017. <https://www.google.com/policies/privacy/>.

b) **Notes & Bibliography**

1. **Book**

Footnote: Grazer and Fishman, *Curious Mind*, 37.

Bibliography: Grazer, Brian, and Charles Fishman. *A Curious Mind: The Secret to a Bigger Life*. New York: Simon & Schuster, 2015.

2. **Chapter of Edited Book**

Footnote: Thoreau, "Walking," 182.

Bibliography: Thoreau, Henry David. "Walking." In *The Making of the American Essay*, edited by John D'Agata, 167–95. Minneapolis: Graywolf Press, 2016.

3. **E-Book with available link (without link, see 1.)**

Footnote: Kurland and Lerner, *Founders' Constitution*, chap. 4, doc. 29.

Bibliography: Kurland, Philip B., and Ralph Lerner, eds. *The Founders' Constitution*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1987. <http://press-pubs.uchicago.edu/founders/>.

4. **Journal Article**

Footnote: LaSalle, "Conundrum", 101.

Bibliography: LaSalle, Peter. "Conundrum: A Story about Reading." *New England Review* 38, no. 1 (2017): 95–109.

5. **Newspaper Report/ Magazine Article/ Blog Article**

Footnote: Manjoo, "Snap."

Bibliography: Manjoo, Farhad. "Snap Makes a Bet on the Cultural Supremacy of the Camera." *New York Times*, March 8, 2017. <https://www.nytimes.com/2017/03/08/technology/snap-makes-a-bet-on-the-cultural-supremacy-of-the-camera.html>.

6. **Interview**

Footnote: Stamper, interview.

Bibliography: Stamper, Kory. "From 'F-Bomb' to 'Photobomb,' How the Dictionary Keeps Up with English." Interview by Terry Gross. *Fresh Air*, NPR, April 19, 2017. Audio, 35:25. <http://www.npr.org/2017/04/19/524618639/from-f-bomb-to-photobomb-how-the-dictionary-keeps-up-with-english>.

7. **Website**

Footnote: Google, "Privacy Policy."

Bibliography: Google. "Privacy Policy." Privacy & Terms. Last modified April 17, 2017. <https://www.google.com/policies/privacy/Laws>

Footnote: Homeland Security Act of 2002, 6 U.S.C. § 101 (2012).

Bibliography: Homeland Security Act of 2002, 6 U.S.C. § 101 (2012).

8. **Cases & Court Decisions**

Footnote: Christmas, 222 F.3d at 145.

Bibliography: United States v. Christmas, 222 F.3d 141, 145 (4th Cir. 2000).

Source material for examples taken from: Chicago, University of. 2017. *The Chicago Manual of Style*. 17th Edition. Chicago: The University of Chicago Press.